

MK PARRISH

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THE MARGIN NOTES

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THEY WERE WRITING IN CODE

Revelation is not a roadmap for the end times. It is the protest literature of a persecuted community — and reading it that way changes everything.

Eight chapters on the most misread book in the Bible, the people who wrote it, what they were actually saying, and what it means for anyone trying to hold faith while the world is on fire.

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THE MARGIN NOTES SERIES

FOREWORD

BEFORE THE SEALS OPEN

Every few decades, someone publishes a book arguing they've finally cracked Revelation's code. They map the seven seals to current events, identify the Antichrist as the current political figure they find most alarming, and declare that we are definitively, provably, living in the last days.

The Hal Lindsey generation had *The Late Great Planet Earth* in 1970. The Tim LaHaye generation had the Left Behind series. Every generation has its version. Every generation has been wrong. The end hasn't come. The Antichrist turned out to be the wrong person. The timeline failed. And the next generation's version appears, makes the same claims, fails the same way, and is forgotten when the next one arrives.

There is a reason this keeps happening, and it has nothing to do with the failure of prophecy. It has to do with a fundamental misreading of what kind of text Revelation is.

Revelation is not a prophecy in the sense of a future-foretelling timeline. It is an *apocalypse* — and apocalypse, as a literary genre, has specific conventions that its original readers understood and that we, without the context, routinely miss. It is also something more specific: it is the protest literature of a community under persecution, written in a symbolic code designed to communicate clearly

to insiders and obscurely to hostile authorities. It is political. It is urgent. It is addressed to people in a specific time and place who are suffering specific things.

When you read it that way, it becomes a different book. Not less complex — more so, in some ways. But coherent in a way the end-times reading never quite manages. The symbols resolve. The images make sense. And the message turns out to be something far more interesting than a timeline: it is a declaration, made under oppression, that the empires of the world are not the final word.

That is a message worth reading. Especially now.

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CHAPTER 01

WHAT KIND OF BOOK IS THIS

Genre determines meaning — and Revelation's genre has been almost universally misidentified.

The single most important thing you can know about Revelation is what kind of text it is. Not who the Antichrist is. Not what the mark of the beast corresponds to. What literary genre this book belongs to — because genre shapes everything: how you read, what you expect, what counts as meaning, and what counts as error.

Revelation belongs to a genre called *apocalyptic literature*. This is a specific literary form with a specific history, a specific set of conventions, and a specific purpose. It appeared in Jewish literature from roughly 200 BCE to 200 CE — so both before and after the emergence of Christianity — and Revelation is the New Testament's most extensive example of it. The genre has close relatives in the Hebrew Bible: the book of Daniel is the most developed, and there are apocalyptic sections in Isaiah, Ezekiel, and Zechariah.

Apocalyptic literature has several defining features:

- **It is heavenly vision mediated by an angel or divine figure.** The human author receives revelations from a celestial being about things that cannot be known from earthly perspective.

- **It uses highly symbolic imagery.** Animals with multiple heads. Numbers with cosmic significance. Colors and materials that carry encoded meaning. This imagery is not meant to be interpreted literally — it is the symbolic language of the genre, recognizable to readers who know the tradition.
- **It addresses a community under crisis.** Apocalyptic literature almost always emerges in contexts of suffering, persecution, or oppression. It speaks to people who need a cosmic perspective on their immediate suffering — who need to believe that the world as they experience it is not the full story.
- **It declares the ultimate sovereignty of God over present circumstances.** Despite appearances — despite the empire's power, the persecution's severity, the community's vulnerability — God wins. This is not a naive claim. It is a political and theological declaration made by people who know exactly how much it costs to hold it.

PROPHECY VS. APOCALYPSE

Prophecy, in the biblical sense, is not primarily about predicting the future. Biblical prophets — Isaiah, Jeremiah, Amos, Micah — are not fortune-tellers. They are truth-tellers: people who speak the word of God to the present situation, calling communities to accountability, announcing consequences for injustice, declaring the character of God in the face of the people's failures and fears. They do speak about what will happen — but in the context of: if you continue doing this, this is what comes. Not: here is an encrypted timeline of the next two thousand years.

Apocalyptic literature is different. It does not call for repentance or social change in the same way. It calls for *endurance*. The world is bad. The empire is

powerful. People are dying. Hold on. God sees. The end is not what you think it is. Don't worship the beast. Keep going.

Reading Revelation as straightforward predictive prophecy — as a hidden timeline of end-times events addressed to readers in the twenty-first century — is reading the wrong genre. It is reading a first-century protest poem as a contemporary treasure map. The map will be wrong every time because the territory it was drawn for is not ours.

WHAT "REVELATION" ACTUALLY MEANS

The Greek word at the opening of the book is **apokalypsis** — which means uncovering, unveiling, revealing. The book announces itself as a revelation of things that are hidden: a pulling back of the curtain on the spiritual and cosmic reality behind the visible political situation of the first century. The veil between heaven and earth goes thin. What is actually happening — who is actually in charge, what is actually at stake — becomes visible to the one who receives the vision.

This is not a prediction. This is a perception. John is not being shown what will happen in 2025. He is being shown what is happening in 95 CE, from a divine vantage point that makes the truth visible. The empire looks invincible. From here, you can see what it actually is.

That is the book. Read accordingly.

WHO WAS JOHN OF PATMOS

The author, the island, the empire — and the specific circumstances that produced this book.

Revelation opens with its author's self-identification: "I, John, your brother who share with you in Jesus the persecution and the kingdom and the patient endurance, was on the island called Patmos because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus." (Rev. 1:9)

John is on Patmos. Patmos is a small island in the Aegean Sea, approximately 35 miles southwest of Miletus on the Turkish coast. It was used by Rome as a site of exile — a penal colony to which political prisoners and troublesome figures were sent. John is there for a specific reason: "because of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus." He is a prisoner of the Roman Empire, exiled for his faith.

This is the context in which Revelation was written: by a prisoner, in exile, for communities under the direct authority of an empire that has demonstrated both its willingness and its capacity to kill people for not conforming to imperial religious requirements. This is not a comfortable theological text written in a study. This is resistance literature produced under the specific conditions of Roman imperial persecution.

WHICH JOHN

The author calls himself John. He does not call himself John the apostle, John the son of Zebedee, or John the author of the Gospel. Early church tradition identified him with John the apostle, but scholars since at least Dionysius of Alexandria (third century) have noted that the Greek of Revelation is strikingly different from the Greek of the Gospel of John — rougher, less polished, with different vocabulary and idiom — and have questioned whether they share an author.

The scholarly consensus today is that "John of Patmos" and "John the evangelist" (author of the Gospel) are probably different people. This does not affect the canonical status of Revelation, which stands on its own authority. It does affect the romantic image of a beloved disciple, exiled in old age, receiving visions of the future. The John of Revelation may be an otherwise unknown Jewish-Christian prophet, living in or near the province of Asia, exiled to Patmos during a period of Roman persecution — probably in the reign of Domitian, around 95 CE.

THE DOMITIAN CONTEXT

The Emperor Domitian (81–96 CE) demanded to be addressed as "Lord and God" — *dominus et deus*. He expanded the imperial cult, the system of religious observance centered on the worship of the emperor and the Roman gods, which was deeply integrated into civic and economic life throughout the provinces. Refusing to participate in the imperial cult was not simply a religious nonconformity. It had social and economic consequences: you could be excluded from guilds, from markets, from civic participation. It could mark you as subversive. It could get you killed.

The seven churches addressed in Revelation chapters 2–3 are in the province of Asia — modern western Turkey. They are communities living under these exact

pressures. They are being pressured to accommodate, to participate at least nominally in the imperial cult, to survive by compromise. John writes to them from exile, with the authority of someone who has already paid the price for nonaccommodation, to say: don't. Do not worship the beast. Do not take its mark. What looks like survival is capitulation, and what looks like defeat is witness.

This is not abstract theology. This is urgent pastoral correspondence from a prisoner to communities facing real danger.

CHAPTER 03

ROME AS BABYLON

The central code of Revelation — and why using code was not dishonesty but survival.

The most important interpretive key to Revelation is also the most obvious, once you know to look for it: Babylon is Rome.

Throughout Revelation, a great city called Babylon appears — a city described as the seat of empire, drunk on the blood of saints, the center of global commerce, the source of persecution for the community John is writing to. This city is spectacular and terrifying. It sits on seven hills. Its fall is celebrated by heaven. Its destruction is lamented by the merchants and kings of the earth who profited from its power.

First-century readers would have recognized this immediately. Rome, the city famously built on seven hills. Rome, the commercial center of the known world. Rome, the persecutor of Christians. John is not being cryptic for mystical reasons. He is being cryptic because he is writing political resistance literature under a political system that executed people for exactly this kind of speech, and he is using the conventions of the apocalyptic genre — which his readers understood — to say what cannot be said plainly without immediate reprisal.

This calls for a mind that has wisdom: the seven heads are seven mountains on which the woman is seated; also they are seven kings...

The text practically tells you. Seven mountains. There is only one city in the ancient world proverbially described as the city on seven hills. John is naming it in code.

WHY BABYLON

The choice of Babylon as the code name for Rome is not random. It is theologically loaded. Babylon was the empire that had destroyed Jerusalem, burned the Temple, and taken Israel into exile in 587 BCE. For Jewish readers — and John's Christian community emerged from Jewish tradition — Babylon was the archetype of the empire that destroys what is sacred and exiles the people of God. Calling Rome "Babylon" is naming Rome as the same kind of entity: empire as such, the power that opposes God's people and God's purposes.

It is also, notably, a historical allusion that places Rome in a larger story. Babylon fell. The exile ended. The Temple was rebuilt. The empire that seemed permanent was not. By naming Rome as Babylon, John is implicitly claiming: this, too, will not last. The arc is longer than what you can see from here.

THE OTHER CODES

Babylon is not the only code in Revelation. The number 666, the "mark of the beast," is another. In the ancient world, names were converted to numbers through a system called gematria — each letter had a numerical value, and the letters of a name could be added to produce a sum. The most widely supported scholarly reading of 666 is that it is the numerical value of "Neron Caesar" in Hebrew transliteration — Nero, the emperor who had already by the 90s become synonymous with the persecution of Christians. He was dead by then,

but the fear of his return, or of a ruler like him, was alive in the communities John was writing to.

John is not encoding a prediction about a future world leader. He is speaking, in code, about the specific political reality his communities were living in. The beast is the empire. The mark is the accommodation the empire required. The choice not to take the mark is the choice to refuse collaboration, even at enormous personal cost.

This reading is not modern or liberal. It is the reading of the early church, of many church fathers, and of a substantial majority of contemporary biblical scholars across the theological spectrum. The end-times reading — in which these codes are predicted future realities to be decoded by the modern reader — is historically recent, culturally specific (primarily North American evangelical), and has no support in the ancient world.

THE SEVEN CHURCHES

Who they were, what they were actually dealing with, and what John's letters to them reveal about faith under pressure.

Chapters 2 and 3 of Revelation contain letters to seven specific churches in the province of Asia. These are not symbolic churches representing eras of church history — they are real communities in real cities: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea. John knows them. He knows their situations. The letters are pastoral and specific.

What the letters reveal is the specific shape of the pressure these communities were under. Some were doing well. Some had compromised. Some were suffering. Some had lost their first love. The letters diagnose and prescribe with the specificity of someone who understands what is actually happening in each place.

SMYRNA: SUFFERING AND POVERTY

I know your affliction and your poverty, even though you are rich, and the slander of those who say that they are Jews and are not, but are a synagogue of Satan.

Smyrna is a community under economic pressure. They are poor — likely because participation in the guilds and markets of the city required religious observance they refused. They are also experiencing slander from a local community John calls the "synagogue of Satan" — a phrase that has been used harmfully in anti-Semitic contexts and must be read carefully. It refers, in its first-century context, to a specific local dispute between Jewish Christians and other Jewish communities about who constitutes the authentic people of God. It is not a universal condemnation of Jewish communities. It is the heated language of an intra-communal conflict in a specific city.

John's word to Smyrna: do not fear. You are about to suffer more. Be faithful unto death. You are rich in ways that don't show up in your bank account.

LAODICEA: COMFORTABLE COMPROMISE

I know your works; you are neither cold nor hot. I wish that you were either cold or hot. So, because you are lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I am about to spit you out of my mouth. For you say, "I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing." You do not realize that you are wretched, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked.

REVELATION 3:15-17

Laodicea is a prosperous city. It was famous for its banking industry, its textile production, and its eye salve — details John explicitly references. The church in Laodicea has apparently achieved the kind of material success that made

accommodation to the imperial cult easy. They are not being persecuted because they are not threatening. They have found a way to be comfortable.

John's word to Laodicea is the harshest of the seven letters. Not because of their sin in the conventional sense. Because of their compromise. Their willingness to be neither one thing nor the other. Their inability to be disturbed. The lukewarm church that has confused prosperity with faithfulness.

This letter has a particular bite when read in context. Laodicea's water supply was famously neither hot (like Hierapolis's thermal springs, used medicinally) nor cold (like Colossae's cool, refreshing water). The lukewarm water arrived via aqueduct, tepid and unpleasant. John's metaphor would have landed with immediate, visceral force. Your community is like your water: useful for nothing. Take a side.

WHAT THE SEVEN LETTERS ARE DOING

The seven letters establish the pastoral ground of Revelation before the visions begin. John knows his communities. He knows which ones are suffering and which are comfortable. He knows which have held the line and which have accommodated. He writes to all of them — the suffering and the comfortable, the faithful and the compromised — because all of them are about to receive the same vision: a cosmic perspective on the empire they're navigating.

The suffering communities need to know: what you're enduring is not meaningless. The comfortable communities need to know: what you've traded away is not nothing. The visions that follow are addressed to both.

THE LAMB VS. THE BEAST

The central theological conflict of Revelation — and why it's a conflict about power, not just about evil.

The central drama of Revelation is a conflict between two figures: the Lamb and the Beast. This conflict is presented in cosmic and symbolic terms, but its content is fundamentally political — a contest over who gets to define power, who gets to be worshipped, and what counts as strength in the world.

The Beast is the empire. We've established that. It demands worship. It marks its subjects. It persecutes those who refuse. It appears invincible. Its wound has healed and people say: who can fight against it?

Then I saw a Lamb standing as if it had been slaughtered, having seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven spirits of God sent out into all the earth.

REVELATION 5:6

The Lamb. John is told to look for a Lion — the conquering lion of Judah, the powerful messiah — and what he sees when he looks is a Lamb. Not a triumphant Lamb but a slaughtered Lamb, still bearing the marks of its killing.

Standing. Dead and alive simultaneously. The one who has been killed is the one with authority. The wound is not a vulnerability. It is the credential.

THE INVERSION OF POWER

This is the central theological claim of Revelation, and it is a radical one: power works differently than empires say it does. The Beast accumulates. It demands. It wounds. It claims. It destroys. The Lamb was destroyed and rose. Its power is not the power of domination but the power of witness — *martyria*, which gives us the word "martyr." The one who testifies faithfully, even to death, participates in the power that outlasts the empire.

Revelation does not teach passivity. It does not teach that suffering is good or that endurance is the whole of faithful response. It teaches that the violence of the empire is not the final account of the world. That the seemingly defeated — the slaughtered — have access to a power the empire does not control and cannot destroy.

This was not abstract consolation. It was a claim made to people who were watching members of their community die. Some of them would die. John knows this. He says so. The point is not that death won't come. The point is that death is not the final word — and that the empire's ability to deliver death does not make it sovereign.

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*The Lamb wins not despite the wound but through it.
Power that comes from faithfulness unto death is power
the empire has no weapon against.*

THE MARK OF THE BEAST, RECONSIDERED

The mark of the beast — 666, placed on the forehead or hand — is one of the most sensationalized images in popular Revelation interpretation. It has been variously identified as credit cards, barcodes, RFID chips, social security numbers, and COVID vaccines. These readings share one thing: they look for a literal, physical mark to be wary of in a contemporary context.

The first-century meaning is different. The "mark" of the beast is the economic and civic marker of imperial accommodation. To take the mark is to participate in the imperial system — to buy and sell within it, to worship within it, to signal your loyalty to it. It is the opposite of the "seal" that marks the servants of God (Rev. 7:3) — which is also not a literal seal but a marker of belonging, of whose you are.

In context: the choice between the mark of the beast and the seal of God is the choice between accommodation to the empire and witness against it. It is the choice Laodicea made the wrong way. It is the choice Smyrna was being pressured toward. It is a choice with immediate, real economic and social consequences — not a future science fiction scenario.

The question the mark asks — whose are you, really? — is not irrelevant today. It just isn't best answered by checking the back of your hand.

THE WOMEN IN REVELATION

Jezebel, the whore of Babylon, the woman clothed with the sun — and what the symbolic women of Revelation actually represent.

Revelation has a complicated relationship with female figures. It contains some of the most vivid female symbolism in the entire Bible — and some of it has been weaponized against women in ways that require careful examination.

There are three major female figures in Revelation: the woman clothed with the sun (chapter 12), the great whore of Babylon (chapters 17–18), and the bride of Christ / new Jerusalem (chapter 21–22). There is also a fourth figure named in the letters: Jezebel of Thyatira (chapter 2).

Let's be clear from the outset: these are not women. They are symbolic figures using female imagery in the conventions of ancient Near Eastern symbolism. The "great whore of Babylon" is not a critique of women or female sexuality. She is a symbolic representation of Rome — of the empire — using the conventions of personified cities that go back through the Hebrew prophets (Tyre, Babylon, Jerusalem are all personified as women in the prophetic literature). The sexualization of the imagery reflects the prophetic tradition's use of sexual imagery for political and commercial unfaithfulness. It is not about women.

THE WOMAN CLOTHED WITH THE SUN

A great portent appeared in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet, and on her head a crown of twelve stars. She was pregnant and was crying out in birth pangs, in the agony of giving birth.

REVELATION 12:1-2

This woman is one of the most powerful images in Revelation. She is cosmic — clothed with astronomical bodies. She is in labor, birthing a child who will rule the nations. She is pursued by a great red dragon. She flees into the wilderness where God has prepared a place for her. She is given the wings of an eagle to escape.

Who is she? Most scholars read her as a composite figure: she represents Israel (the twelve stars echo the twelve tribes, the twelve apostles), the church, or the community from which the Messiah comes. She is not the Virgin Mary in the Catholic devotional sense, though Catholic tradition has read her that way. She is a symbol of the people of God in their vulnerability and their protection.

What is striking about this figure: she is fierce, cosmic, and actively struggling. She is not passive. She is in labor — the hardest physical work the human body does — and she is being pursued by the forces of the empire/dragon, and she survives. God protects her. She is given eagle's wings. She makes it through.

This is a female figure that is powerful precisely in her vulnerability. The birth pangs are real. The dragon is real. The danger is real. And she persists. She is not a victim. She is a survivor, protected not because she avoids the struggle but because she goes through it with divine protection.

JEZEBEL OF THYATIRA

But I have this against you: you tolerate that woman Jezebel, who calls herself a prophet and is teaching and beguiling my servants to practice fornication and to eat food sacrificed to idols.

REVELATION 2:20

"Jezebel" is almost certainly not this woman's actual name. It is a polemical name — invoking the queen Jezebel of the Hebrew Bible who led Israel into the worship of Baal — applied to a prophetic figure in the Thyatira church who is teaching accommodation to the imperial cult. The "fornication" and "food sacrificed to idols" are almost certainly references to participation in the imperial religious practices, not literal sexual behavior. This is consistent with how the prophets used the language of adultery and fornication for religious unfaithfulness throughout the Hebrew Bible.

John's criticism of this figure is not that she is a woman teaching. It is that she is teaching accommodation — that it is acceptable to participate in the imperial cult. This is the same problem he has with Laodicea. The gendered naming ("that woman Jezebel") is polemical but it is not the point. The point is the content of the teaching, not the gender of the teacher. John, elsewhere, shows no problem with prophetic women per se — the daughters who prophesy appear without critique in related New Testament texts.

THE GREAT WHORE: A NOTE

The "great whore of Babylon" — the female personification of Rome — has been used throughout history to stigmatize women, female sexuality, and women in power. The connection between "powerful woman" and "whore" that Revelation's image enables is not incidental; it has been actively exploited.

The image belongs to the prophetic tradition of personifying cities and nations as women — a literary convention, not a statement about women. Babylon-as-Rome is represented as a woman because cities and nations were grammatically and symbolically feminine in ancient languages, and because the prophetic tradition already had an established vocabulary for political unfaithfulness in sexual terms (Hosea, Ezekiel, Jeremiah). The image is not about women. It has been made to be about women by readers who found it useful.

When you encounter this figure in Revelation, read her as what she is: a literary symbol for the empire that is drunk on the blood of the martyrs, whose seductive power is really political and economic domination dressed up as civilization. She is not a woman. She is a city. She is a system. She falls at the end — and her fall is not the defeat of women. It is the defeat of empire.

CHAPTER 07

WHAT "RAPTURE" IS **NOT** IN THIS BOOK

The doctrine that isn't in Revelation — where it came from, and why it matters that so many people believe it's there.

The rapture is not in Revelation. I want to say this as plainly as possible, because it is one of the most widespread misreadings of the book and one of the ones that has done the most theological damage.

The "rapture" doctrine — the belief that faithful Christians will be supernaturally removed from the earth before a period of tribulation, while those left behind experience judgment — is not taught in Revelation. It is not a reading of Revelation. It was derived primarily from a single passage in 1 Thessalonians 4 and one in 1 Corinthians 15, then mapped onto Revelation's structure by a specific theological tradition beginning in the nineteenth century.

WHERE IT CAME FROM

The rapture doctrine in its modern form is largely the creation of John Nelson Darby, an Anglo-Irish minister who developed it in the 1830s. Darby invented a theological system called Dispensationalism — a way of reading the Bible that divided history into distinct "dispensations" or eras, each with different divine rules. The rapture was part of this system's account of the end times.

Darby's theology spread to America through the Scofield Reference Bible (1909), which was published with Dispensationalist interpretive notes embedded in the text itself — meaning readers could not read the Bible without reading Darby's commentary alongside it. The Scofield Bible was enormously influential in American evangelical Christianity and embedded Dispensationalism as the default eschatological framework for millions of readers.

The Left Behind series, Hal Lindsey's work, and virtually all of popular end-times theology in the American context is Dispensationalist. It is a nineteenth-century theological invention that reads like first-century prophecy because it has been marketed so successfully for so long that most people assume it has ancient roots.

It does not. No church father taught the rapture. No Reformation theologian taught it. It was invented in the 1830s.

WHAT REVELATION ACTUALLY PROMISES

Revelation does not promise escape. It promises presence and perseverance. The communities John writes to are not told: endure a little longer and then you'll be removed. They are told: endure. God sees. The Lamb has overcome. The empire is not the final word. *Stay.*

Here is a call for the endurance and faith of the saints.

REVELATION 13:10

Here is a call for the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and hold fast to the faith of Jesus.

REVELATION 14:12

Endurance. Not escape. The call of Revelation is to stay in the world, maintain witness, refuse accommodation to the empire, and trust that the cosmic story being revealed to John is more true than what the empire would have you believe about its own permanence.

This is a harder, more demanding, and more interesting message than "you'll be raptured before it gets really bad." It is a message for people who understand that faith is not protection from suffering but orientation within it. It is a message that has kept communities alive through real persecution throughout history, because it tells the truth: it will be hard, and God is with you in it, and the empire that is killing you is not the final account of the world.

WHAT IT MEANS TO HOLD THIS BOOK **NOW**

Revelation's vision of a new creation — and what it asks of anyone who takes it seriously in the present moment.

Revelation ends with a vision. Not a rescue. Not an escape. A renewal.

Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more. And I saw the holy city, the new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband. And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, "See, the home of God is among mortals. He will dwell with them; they will be his peoples, and God himself will be with them; he will wipe every tear from their eyes. Death will be no more; mourning and crying and pain will be no more, for the first things have passed away."

REVELATION 21:1–4

The new Jerusalem does not come up from the earth. It comes **down** from heaven. This is the detail that most people miss. The location of the consummation is not heaven, where the faithful have escaped to. It is a renewed earth, where God comes to be with humans. The direction of travel is downward, not upward. The promise is not escape from the world but the transformation of it.

This matters because it shapes what faithfulness looks like in the present. If the promise is escape, then the world's suffering is not really your problem — you'll be gone before the worst of it. If the promise is renewal, then the world's suffering is absolutely your problem, because it is the world you are called to inhabit faithfully until the God who is coming to transform it arrives.

REVELATION AS RESOURCE, NOT ROADMAP

The question for people living in this moment — in a world with more than enough empire, more than enough persecution, more than enough pressure to accommodate and compromise and survive at the cost of your integrity — is not: who is the Antichrist, and what should I do with my finances before the tribulation? The question is: what does it mean to be faithful in a world where the powers that shape my life are neither just nor particularly interested in becoming so?

Revelation has an answer. It's not a comfortable answer. It's the answer of a prisoner on an island, writing to people who are dying for their convictions, looking at a vision of a God who sees what the empire sees and calls it something different. The answer is: refuse accommodation. Maintain witness. Remember that what looks permanent isn't. Trust that what looks defeated isn't.

The Lamb wins. Not by accumulating the beast's weapons. Not by becoming the beast's mirror image. By remaining the Lamb — by the power of faithfulness, testimony, and a willingness to go through death rather than around it.

WHAT THIS ASKS OF WOMEN SPECIFICALLY

The series that this book belongs to is specifically for women — for women who have been handed a version of the Christian tradition that diminished them and

who are trying to figure out what to do with that. So let me say something specifically to you about Revelation.

The tradition that misread Revelation as an end-times timeline is the same tradition that used the Bible to silence women, that read "helper" into ezer, that made Eve the villain of the fall, that chose "but" when the Hebrew said "and." These are not separate errors. They are the same error: reading the text through a lens that prioritizes certain kinds of power and control, and finding in the text support for that prioritization.

The Revelation that is actually there — the protest literature of a community under oppression, bearing witness against empire at personal cost — is a text that has something specific to say to anyone who has been excluded, minimized, or told that their voice and presence are dangerous. It says: the powers that exclude you are not the final word. The structures that silence you are Babylon, not God. The Lamb that wins is the one that refused to become the beast, even when the beast had all the obvious power.

You do not have to read this book as a terrifying end-times thriller. You can read it as what it is: a letter to people who needed to know they were seen, that the suffering was real, that the empire would not last, and that the one who was slaughtered is the one who stands. Still. Always.

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The home of God is among mortals. Not in a heaven you escape to. Here. In the world you live in. In the community you belong to. In the body you carry. That is where God is coming. That is what the vision says.

FOR FURTHER READING

- **N.T. Wright** — *Revelation for Everyone*. A readable, accessible commentary that takes the first-century context seriously without requiring scholarly background.
- **Barbara Rossing** — *The Rapture Exposed*. The best popular-level demolition of the rapture doctrine and its historical origins. Direct, well-sourced, and useful for people raised in Dispensationalist contexts.
- **Wes Howard-Brook and Anthony Gwyther** — *Unveiling Empire: Reading Revelation Then and Now*. The most rigorous treatment of Revelation's political and imperial context I've found for general readers.
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